
TUG4

THE STORY SO FAR

From the Blackford Road to the Clifftop Observatory



PLAYER EDITION | THROUGH SESSION 13

A CHRONICLE OF THE TABLE

Four Roads. One Fracture.

"Some stories begin with prophecy. This one began when five strangers learned that the prophecy was frightened, too."

PART I - THE FRAYING

The impossible warning and the blood on Blackford Road.

PART II - THE ISLAND REMEMBERS

Dragon's Rest, Seagrow Caves, and power awakening under pressure.

PART III - WHAT REFUSES TO STAY BURIED

The Compass Rose, Luskan's reach, and a fault line within the party.

PART IV - ABOVE STORMWRECK

The moonstone bridge, the Clifftop Observatory, and a dragon mining the dead.

Compiled from what happened at the table. Unanswered mysteries remain unanswered.

Five Who Walked Into the Fracture

Not chosen because they were ready. Chosen because they were there.



Brother Kai

A gold dragonborn monk seeking enlightenment while old power sharpens beneath his discipline.



Pat Benatar

A watchful rogue carrying a clan-marked scale and a gift for arriving where danger least expects.



Severed Whisper

A dark-furred Tabaxi rogue pursued by Luskan, drawn to lost roads, and never to be called kitty.



Throk

An orc warlock from Many-Arrows learning that protection can be the hardest form of strength.



Floyd GoldSeeker

A dwarf cleric and master surveyor who carries a miner's hammer and the memory of a buried crew.

A Trail of Wounds and Warnings

Each place answered a different question. None answered the first one.



*The road ends at a locked tower.
The story does not.*



PROLOGUE

The Warning That Had No Answer

Before Stormwreck Isle, before the dead ship and the ruined tower, there was a shared silence. During deep meditation, five minds were pulled somewhere beyond the world they knew. An impossible being met them in the shape of an ancient spellcaster - not its true form, only a translation their thoughts could survive.

It warned them that the crisis was larger than any cult, town, god, or temple. Across realities, time, space, religion, magic, prayer, memory, and reality itself had begun to fray. Then came the most frightening truth: the being did not know why.

Their first prophecy did not give them an answer. It gave them a witness.



SESSIONS 1-8

Blood on the Blackford Road

Shorn's caravan was moving north when orcs struck from the roadside. Grusk and Morghul led the ambush, and the violence carried more than a raider's hunger: it looked like an attempt to sabotage the fragile peace Throk's father had helped build.

Three young orcs and their wolf died. Grusk and Morghul escaped into the hills. Throk, wounded but standing, chose to fight beside the merchants and earned a place in their company. Somewhere behind the ordinary prayers of ordinary people, whispers of a cult devoted to "the one god" also began to surface.

On that road, peace stopped being an idea. It became something that could bleed.



SESSION 9

Fire Over Cold Water

Captain Elric Thorne carried the company toward Stormwreck Isle, and Floyd GoldSeeker joined the journey. The voyage did not stay quiet. Dragonborn breath flashed across the boat, much to the captain's irritation, and the table answered every blast with a shot of Fireball.

At the dock, zombies rose to bar the landing. Throk fell. Pat Benatar kept him alive with quick hands and a clear head. Then power answered Throk for the first time: an Eldritch Blast he could cast but could not yet explain. Sev, Kai, and Floyd each brought down one of the dead.

Stormwreck greeted them with salt, flame, and corpses that had forgotten to lie still.



SESSIONS 9-10

The Hill Called Dragon's Rest

Wounded and exhausted, the company climbed from the dock and met the kobolds of Dragon's Rest. Myla borrowed Throk's axe while cheerfully mistaking it for a sword. Tarak came down the hill with Severed Whisper and healed the battered travelers. Runara received them into a refuge that felt gentle without ever feeling ordinary.

She noticed Pat Benatar's clan-marked scale. She noticed the discipline coiled inside Brother Kai. Tarak, meanwhile, needed medicinal fungus from Seagrow Caves, where the air and fungal colony had turned dangerously sick.

Dragon's Rest offered safety, but the island beneath it was remembering old deaths.



SESSION 10

When Discipline Grew Claws

The company crossed by canoe into Seagrow Caves and found the myconids there were not monsters. They were a people living inside a wound. Fungal life dimmed under poisoned heat and trapped fumes, while deeper in the cavern something pulsed behind crystal and smoke.

Brother Kai meditated before the elder mushrooms. The power that answered him did not arrive as a serene vision. Dragon claws awakened from his disciplined hands - ancient, immediate, and impossible to dismiss. In the battle that followed, his first strike missed. His next found its mark.

The question was no longer whether Kai possessed a weapon. It was what the weapon reached for.



SESSION 10

Smoke, Sulfur, and the Last Drake

The fume drakes turned the crystal cave into a choking furnace. Floyd struck hard. Throk landed a blow and then went down, only for Floyd to pull him back into the fight. Pat Benatar searched for the perfect opening, missed twice, and still delivered the final kill when it mattered.

The dying drake burst in smoke, heat, and sulfurous force. Brother Kai fell. Throk spent the party's only healing potion to bring him back. When the haze thinned, the true obstruction remained: an orange fire crystal wedged into the cave's throat, sealing the vent and poisoning everything behind it.

Victory left them alive, empty-handed, and standing in front of the real problem.



SESSION 11

What Happens After the Blow

Throk understood the crystal as pressure made solid. He set the rope and led the pull. When the stone tore loose, the vent erupted in fire, fumes, and razor-bright fragments. Ancestral shields formed around the company, and an orcish presence spoke through the blast.

"Strength is not rage. Strength is choosing what happens after the blow lands."

The shields blunted the eruption. Floyd still fell. A fire snake emerged from the broken vent, and the company killed it together. As smoke escaped and clean air returned, Throk's strange power finally showed its shape: not corruption, not softness, but the strength to hold a line for others.



SESSION 11

The Cave Takes a Breath

With the vent open, Seagrow Caves began to heal. The elder mushrooms wrapped Floyd in white spores and fine fungal threads, restoring the fallen surveyor and recognizing the company that had freed their home. They gave the travelers the medicinal fungus Tarak needed.

Back at Dragon's Rest, Runara gave language to what they had seen. Stormwreck Isle remembers dragon deaths through stone, sea, cave, and wreck. Kai's claws were older than a simple curse. Pat's scale belonged to the same buried mystery. Throk's new strength had answered with protection.

The caves were breathing again. Around the island, other dead things were not.



SESSION 11

The Compass Rose

The cursed shipwreck lay half-sunk against the rocks, broken open and slick with seawater. It was not merely ruined. It was occupied by death that had learned the shape of old fear. The company climbed through rotted decks and fought the dead among snapped timbers and flooded shadows.

Above them, Brother Kai reached the crow's nest. A harpy's song caught Severed Whisper and Throk, and the creature struck Kai down high over the wreck. Below, the Compass Rose groaned against the stone as if the island itself were refusing to let it drift away.

The caves had shown sickness. The wreck showed memory with teeth.



SESSIONS 11-12

The Song Ends in Fire

Pat Benatar climbed toward the crow's nest while the harpy's song held two of her companions and Kai lay fallen beside the mast. She closed the distance and answered music with dragon breath. The harpy died in the blast, and its charm broke.

When the company returned to the wreck's interior, Floyd healed Kai. Sev stayed low in the dinghy and studied the vessel from outside. The Compass Rose was hopelessly unseaworthy - but it was not empty of the living. Fresh rope, a clean knot, wet boot prints, and a strange crossbow bolt all said that someone else had boarded.

Pat ended one danger. Sev noticed the next before it spoke.



SESSION 12

Severed Whisper Takes the Mast

Luskan's bounty hunters came for Severed Whisper among the wreck's broken decks. They knew his name, his connection to Captain Braddock Ironhand, the odd stone, the bar fight, the mayor's son, and the warehouse trouble. The dragonborn were wanted too, but Sev was the clearest target - and worth more alive.

Sev killed the first hunter, burst free with impossible speed, and leapt onto the mast as if the angles of the ship had been waiting for him. Throk killed another with Eldritch Blast. Pat kept pressure on the crossbowman.

For the first time, Sev did not merely escape the trap. He owned every route out of it.



SESSION 12

The Answer Kai Chose

Brother Kai cornered the last bounty hunter and drew out the truth about Luskan's pursuit. Severed Whisper wanted the prisoner left alive for more answers. Kai listened. Then, controlled and cold, he cut the hunter's throat with the claws that had awakened in Seagrow Caves.

It was not rage. That made the choice harder to ignore. The company later found coin and five silver bars, cleared more of the dead below deck, and returned to Dragon's Rest - but no treasure could turn the execution back into a question.

On the Compass Rose, the party discovered a fault line that ran through more than stone.



SESSION 12

What the Island Was Saying

Runara received the company after the wreck and placed their discoveries side by side. The caves had shown sickness in stone, fungus, heat, and breath. The Compass Rose had shown death, memory, fear, and things that refused to stay buried. Now Luskan had reached the island, and Sev's past could no longer be treated as separate from the group.

She pointed them toward the Clifftop Observatory. If the caves revealed what festered below and the wreck what circled at the shore, the ruins above might reveal what was gathering over Stormwreck.

They slept at Dragon's Rest. In the morning, the road climbed into the storm.



SESSION 13

The Moonstone Key

After the long rest, Runara charged the company with reaching the Clifftop Observatory. Myla warned that her brothers, Mek and Minn, might already be there. Before the party left, Runara placed a moonstone key in Floyd GoldSeeker's hands.

The choice drew Floyd's old life into the center of the expedition. Before divine light and battle, he had been a master surveyor of the Goldseeker clan - a dwarf who read pressure, fault, weight, and the hidden ways through stone. At Glittervein, those skills had not been enough to save his crew.

At the Observatory, they would be asked what survival was for.



SESSION 13

The Stone Had Been Struck Twice

The path crossed basalt cut by glassy protrusions and red, branching scars. Sparkrender, a young blue dragon, passed overhead toward the ruins without noticing the travelers below.

Floyd knelt to read the ground. The island had been struck from above, but the fractures also pushed outward from within. His warhammer - shaped by the memory of his old mining pick - reacted to hidden lines of force running through the terrain. Stormwreck was not only taking blows. Something under its skin was answering them.

A surveyor does not only see stone. He sees what happened to it.



SESSION 13

The Bridge That Wasn't There

At the overlook, two marble dragons waited with gold veining under their stone scales. Floyd fitted the moonstone key into a hexagonal hollow. The statues woke, and a shimmering bridge reached across empty air to the ruined Observatory.

For an instant, the cliff became Glittervein again: darkness, falling stone, the silence after his crew stopped digging, and the single golden ray that had once found his heart. A voice met the memory.

"You were not spared to find gold. You were spared to find the way out."

Floyd stepped onto the bridge. The others followed.



SESSION 13

Eight Wings in the Rotunda

Inside the ruined rotunda, Mek and Minn were fighting eight stirges. Six turned on the company while the kobolds held the others. Mek died in the struggle. Minn survived. By the end, every member of the party had killed at least one of the blood-drinking creatures.

Sev skewered the last and said, "I would like to introduce myself. I am sorry..." Then the company examined a golden astronomical instrument bearing five dragon effigies: bronze, gold, brass, blue, and red. Blue energy strained to dominate the rest.

The device did not merely measure the heavens. It measured pressure, timing, dragon death, and hidden power.



SESSION 13

The Buried Crew Keeps Time

Floyd understood Sparkrender's intention. The blue dragon was not studying the dead dragons of Stormwreck. He was mining them.

Pickaxes rang in Floyd's memory. His fallen crew gathered around him as presence, rhythm, and grief. His holy symbol burned gold. The warhammer in his hands became his old tool again, not because he had returned to the mine, but because the work had followed him out.

"You were not the only one buried. Dig."

Power settled into him. Somewhere beneath or inside the Observatory tower, another dragon remained trapped. The company had found the way in. Now they had to find the way down.

Eight Questions Still Breathing

No secret answers. Only the mysteries the party has earned.

1. What is fraying time, space, prayer, magic, memory, and reality across worlds?
2. How deeply has the cult of the "one god" hidden among ordinary worshipers?
3. Where did Grusk and Morghul go after the Blackford Road ambush?
4. Why does Pat Benatar's clan-marked scale belong to Stormwreck's older dragon mysteries?
5. What do Brother Kai's awakened claws reach for when discipline is not enough?
6. What will Throk's ancestral power demand after the blow lands?
7. How far will Luskan reach for Severed Whisper, the odd stone, and the truth he carries?
8. What is Sparkrender mining from the dead dragons - and who is trapped beneath the tower?

THE COMPANY'S LAST CERTAINTY

Mek is dead. Minn survived. Another dragon waits inside the Observatory.

WHERE THE STORY WAITS

BENEATH THE TOWER

A dragon mines the power of the dead.
Another waits beneath the stone.
The storm turns above Stormwreck Isle.

Five companions step deeper.

*"Strength is choosing what happens after the blow lands."
"You were not spared to find gold. You were spared to find the way out."
"You were not the only one buried. Dig."*